

Study Note

UNDERSTANDING BUSINESS COMMUNICATION IN TODAY'S WORKPLACE

BUS201: Business and Human Communication

Understanding Business Communication in Today's Workplace

Topic 1 | Week 1

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UNDERSTANDING BUSINESS COMMUNICATION IN TODAY'S WORKPLACE

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At a small tech startup, communication was mostly done through email. One Monday morning, the CEO, Mr. Ahmed, sent out a company-wide email that read: *"Good morning, team! Let's crush it this week! Keep up the hard work, and remember, we're all in this together!"*

His intention was to motivate the staff for the busy week ahead. But then, he accidentally signed off the email with:

"Warm hugs, Ahmed."

The entire team froze in confusion. Was this a new leadership style? A subtle invitation for better work-life balance?

People started replying with strange responses:

"Thanks, Ahmed! Virtual hugs back!"

"Big bear hug from the IT department!"

By lunchtime, the office was abuzz with people debating if they should end every email with "warm hugs" from now on.

When the CEO finally realized what happened, he sent a follow-up email saying: *"Sorry about the earlier sign-off, everyone. I meant 'Warm regards.' No hugging needed."*

To this day, every Monday, the team jokes by signing off their emails with "Warm hugs"—a reminder of the little slip that brought them closer.

This was just a fun way to show how a small communication mix-up can lead to unexpected, hilarious results! "Writing, communication skills, and organizational skills are scarce everywhere. These skills are in demand across nearly every occupation — and in nearly every occupation they're being requested far more than you'd expect based on standard job profiles. Even fields like IT and engineering want people who can write." — The Human Factor: The Hard Time Employers Have Finding Soft Skills, Burning Glass Technologies

What does this mean? It means that no matter what career path you might follow, improving your communication skills will give you a significant competitive edge in the job market.

WHAT IS COMMUNICATION?

Communication is the process of transferring information and meaning between **senders** and **receivers** using one or more media and communication channels. The essence of communication is sharing — providing data, information, insights, and inspiration in an exchange that benefits both you and the people with whom you are communicating. This sharing can happen in a variety of ways, including a simple and successful transfer of information, a negotiation in which the sender and receiver arrive at an agreed-upon meaning,

and unsuccessful attempts in which the receiver creates a different message than the one the sender intended.

THE CHANGING WORKPLACE

The modern workplace is constantly evolving due to the following several key factors, each of which has brought about significant changes in how businesses operate.

- 1. Advancing Technology:** Technological advancements have transformed the way businesses function, enabling faster communication, automation, and innovation. Tools like artificial intelligence (AI), cloud computing, and automation software are now integral to many industries.
Example: Amazon uses robotics and AI in its warehouses to sort, move, and pack goods, dramatically increasing efficiency. Remote collaboration tools like Zoom and Slack also became essential for businesses during the COVID-19 pandemic, allowing teams to work from anywhere in the world.
- 2. The Information Age:** We live in an era where data and information are valuable resources. The ability to collect, analyze, and act on large amounts of data has revolutionized decision-making and strategic planning in companies.
Example: Netflix uses data analytics to track viewer behavior, which helps them make decisions about content creation, such as producing popular shows like Stranger Things. They also use algorithms to personalize recommendations, enhancing user experience and increasing customer retention.
- 3. Globalization:** Globalization refers to the integration of markets, cultures, and businesses across the world. Companies now operate in multiple countries, meaning they must navigate diverse markets, cultures, and regulations.
Example: McDonald's operates in over 100 countries but adapts its menu to local tastes. For example, in India, McDonald's serves vegetarian options like the McAlloo Tikki Burger to cater to local dietary preferences, which differ from its standard offerings in the U.S.
- 4. Workforce Diversity:** Modern organizations are increasingly diverse, comprising employees from various ethnicities, genders, nationalities, and backgrounds. This diversity can foster creativity, innovation, and more inclusive work environments but also presents challenges in managing different perspectives.
Example: Google is known for promoting diversity and inclusion through its hiring practices. The company's diversity initiatives include employee resource groups and leadership programs for underrepresented minorities. Diverse teams at Google have contributed to innovative products like Google Translate and the Pixel phone, which serve a global audience.
- 5. Team-based Organizations:** Traditional hierarchical structures are shifting towards more flexible, team-based models. Cross-functional teams allow employees from different departments or expertise to collaborate on projects, making the organization more adaptable and innovative.
Example: At Spotify, the music streaming company uses a "squad" system, where small, autonomous teams are responsible for different aspects of product development. Each squad has all the necessary skills, from design to engineering, allowing them to operate independently and innovate faster than in traditional hierarchies.

EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION

Effective communication occurs when the message is not only clearly understood but also prompts the recipient to take action or think differently. This involves clarity, purpose, and engagement in the message.

For example, imagine a manager at a retail store who sends an email to their team saying:
"We need to improve customer satisfaction."

While the message is clear, it may not prompt immediate action. However, if the manager instead says:

"We've noticed customer satisfaction has dropped by 10% this month. Let's greet each customer warmly and ask if they need assistance within the first two minutes of entering the store. This small change can boost our ratings and sales!"

In this case, the message is not only understood but also stimulates action by providing a clear directive. It may also encourage staff to rethink their approach to customer service, leading to a better experience for shoppers.

From: afroze.disha@bracu.ac.bd To: bus201team@bracu.ac.bd Subject: hey there – need ur thoughts ASAP Everyone, So, I'm sending this email because we have to discuss some important stuff for the project. The deadline is kinda close, but not sure when exactly – maybe next week or something? Anyway, just wanted to see what everyone is thinking about it and what needs to be done. I was also thinking we could maybe meet up? Let me know when works, I guess. Oh, btw, some of u still haven't given me those reports from last time. Don't forget to do that when u get a chance. Also, I think we need to finalize the budget too, but no worries for now. Best, Disha	The subject is informal ("hey there") and lacks clarity ("need ur thoughts ASAP"). It doesn't provide a clear idea of what the email is about.
	The greeting is cold and off-putting.
	The tone is too casual and contains slang ("u," "kinda," "btw," "stuff," etc.), which is inappropriate for a business email.
	The deadline is vague ("not sure when exactly"). This creates confusion.
	The email does not give clear instructions about what recipients need to do ("just wanted to see what everyone is thinking").
	A negative, accusatory tone puts readers on the defensive, and the request for action fails to clarify who needs to do what by when.
	The email jumps from topic to topic (meeting times, reports, budget) without clear structure, making it hard to follow.
	The email lacks details about important items like the reports and budget.
	The lack of a closing (such as "Thank you,") contributes to a rather harsh, abrupt tone.
	The closing is informal ("Best") and lacks a proper sign-off or contact information.

From: afroze.disha@bracu.ac.bd

To: bus201team@bracu.ac.bd

Subject: Urgent: Project Discussion, Deadlines, and Next Steps

Dear Team,

I hope this email finds you well. I'm writing to discuss some important updates regarding the project and to outline the next steps as we approach the deadline.

1. Project Deadline:

The project deadline is set for Friday, October 22. Please ensure that all tasks are completed by this date. If you encounter any issues that may cause delays, kindly inform me as soon as possible.

2. Pending Reports:

Several team members have yet to submit their reports from last week's meeting. Please send them to me by Wednesday, October 18, so we can review the data and proceed accordingly.

3. Budget Finalization:

We also need to finalize the project budget. I'd appreciate it if the finance team could send me the updated figures by Thursday, October 19. This will allow us to stay on track financially.

4. Team Meeting:

I suggest scheduling a brief meeting to discuss the progress and address any concerns. Please reply with your availability by the end of the day so we can arrange a suitable time.

Thank you for your cooperation, and I look forward to your updates.

Best Regards,

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Benefits of Effective Communication

Following are the various benefits of effective communication in a business context.

- ⊕ **Improved Stakeholder Response:** Effective communication ensures that stakeholders, such as customers, investors, or employees, respond more positively, leading to better relationships and cooperation.
- ⊕ **Quicker Problem Solving:** Clear communication helps teams understand issues faster, leading to quicker resolution of problems.
- ⊕ **Stronger Decision Making:** When communication is transparent and efficient, decision-makers have the necessary information to make well-informed choices.

- ⊕ **Increased Productivity:** Good communication streamlines processes, reducing misunderstandings and boosting the productivity of teams.
- ⊕ **Steadier Workflow:** Clear instructions and feedback improve workflow stability, ensuring smoother operations and less disruption.
- ⊕ **Stronger Business Relationships:** Open and honest communication strengthens trust and collaboration between businesses and their partners, customers, or employees.
- ⊕ **Clearer Promotional Materials:** Effective communication ensures that promotional content, such as marketing materials, is easy to understand and aligns with the target audience's needs.
- ⊕ **Enhanced Professional Image:** Good communication helps project a more professional and credible image, which can improve the company's reputation and attract more business opportunities.

In summary, **effective communication enhances decision-making, productivity, relationships, and problem-solving**, all of which are crucial for business success.

THE BASIC COMMUNICATION MODEL

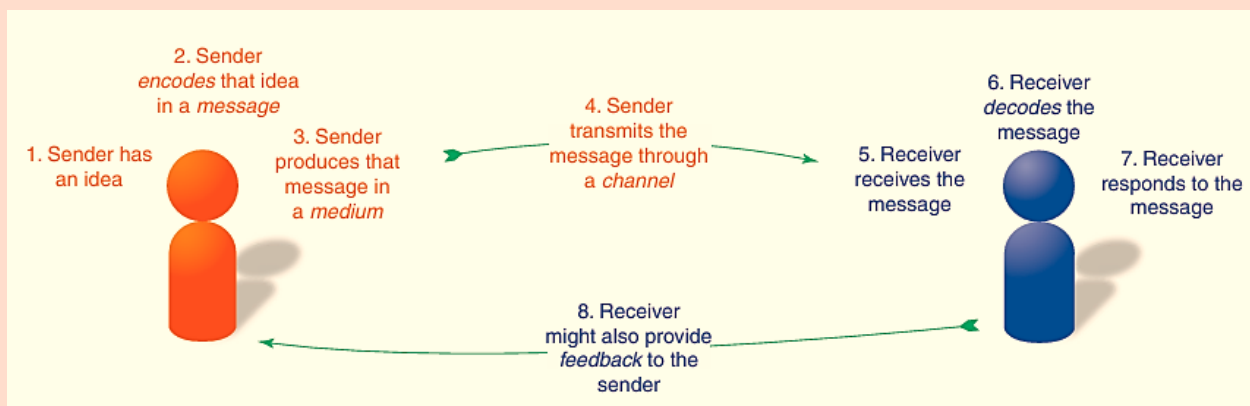


Figure 1.4 The Basic Communication Process

This eight-step model is a simplified view of how communication works in real life; understanding this basic model is vital to improving your communication skills.

Many variations of the communication process model exist, but the following eight steps provide a practical overview (see Figure 1.4).

1. **The sender has an idea.** Whether a communication effort will ultimately be effective starts right here and depends on the nature of the idea and the motivation for sending it. For example, if your motivation is to offer a solution to a problem, you have a better chance of crafting a successful message than if your motivation is merely to complain about the problem.
2. **The sender encodes the idea as a message.** When someone puts an idea into a **message**, he or she is **encoding** it, or expressing it in words or images. Much of the focus of this course is on developing the skills needed to successfully encode your ideas into effective messages.

3. **The sender produces the message in a transmittable medium.** With the appropriate message to express an idea, the sender now needs a **communication medium** to present that message to the intended receiver. To update your boss on the status of a project, for instance, you might have several media options at your disposal, from a phone call to an instant message to a slideshow presentation. Each medium has its own strengths and weaknesses.
4. **The sender transmits the message through a channel.** As technology continues to increase the number of media options, it continues to provide new **communication channels** senders can use to transmit their messages. The distinction between medium and channel can get a bit murky, but think of the medium as the **form** a message takes (written versus spoken, for example) and the channel as the system used to **deliver** the message (email versus a printed letter for a written message, for example).
5. **The intended audience receives the message.** If the channel functions properly, the message reaches its intended audience. However, mere arrival is not enough. For a message to truly be received, the recipient has to **sense** the presence of a message, **select** it from all the other messages clamoring for attention, and **perceive** it as an actual message (as opposed to random noise).
6. **The receiver decodes the message.** After a message is received, the receiver needs to extract the idea from the message, a step known as **decoding**. Even well-crafted, well intentioned communication efforts can fail at this stage because extracting meaning is a highly personal process that is influenced by culture, experience, learning and thinking styles, hopes, fears, and even temporary moods. As you saw in Figure 1.1, receivers sometimes decode the same meaning the sender intended, but sometimes they can decode—or re-create—entirely different meanings. Moreover, receivers tend to extract the meaning they **expect** to get from a message, even if it's the opposite of what the sender intended.
7. **The receiver responds to the message.** In most instances, senders want to accomplish more than simply delivering information. They often want receivers to respond in particular ways, whether it's to invest millions of dollars in a new business venture or to accept management's explanation for why the company can't afford to give employee bonuses this year. Whether a receiver responds as the sender hopes depends on the receiver (a) **remembering** the message long enough to act on it, (b) being able to act on it, and (c) being **motivated** to respond.
8. **The receiver provides feedback.** If a mechanism is available for them to do so, receivers can "close the loop" in the communication process by giving **feedback** that helps the sender evaluate the effectiveness of the communication effort. Feedback can be verbal (using written or spoken words), nonverbal (using gestures, facial expressions, or other signals), or both. Just like the original message, however, this feedback from the receiver also needs to be decoded carefully. A smile, for example, can have many different meanings.

Considering the complexity of this process — and the barriers and distractions that often stand between sender and receiver — it should come as no surprise that communication efforts frequently fail to achieve the sender's objective. Fortunately, the better you understand the process, the more successful you'll be.

The following example illustrates how the communication process works step by step, from generating an idea to receiving feedback.

Scenario: A Team Leader Updates a Manager on Project Progress

1. The sender has an idea.

- ⊕ **Example:** Sarah, a team leader, realizes that the project her team is working on is falling behind schedule. Her idea is to inform her manager about this issue and propose an adjustment to the deadline.

2. The sender encodes the idea as a message.

- ⊕ **Example:** Sarah carefully crafts an email to her manager, explaining the delay, the reasons behind it (like unexpected technical issues), and her suggestion to extend the deadline by one week. She ensures her message is clear and professional.

3. The sender produces the message in a transmittable medium.

- ⊕ **Example:** Sarah chooses email as the medium because it allows her to document the issue formally and send it at any time. Email is also appropriate for project updates in her company.

4. The sender transmits the message through a channel.

- ⊕ **Example:** Sarah uses the company's email system (the channel) to send her email to her manager. She double-checks the recipient's email address to make sure it's correct.

5. The intended audience receives the message.

- ⊕ **Example:** Sarah's manager, David, checks his inbox and sees the email from Sarah among other messages. He opens the email, making the decision to focus on her message.

6. The receiver decodes the message.

- ⊕ **Example:** David reads Sarah's email and understands that the project is delayed due to technical challenges. He also decodes her suggestion to extend the deadline by a week. Since Sarah was clear and thorough in her message, David understands exactly what she's proposing.

7. The receiver responds to the message.

- ⊕ **Example:** After reading the email, David decides to approve Sarah's request for an extension. He agrees with her reasoning and is happy with how she is handling the situation.

8. The receiver provides feedback.

- ⊕ **Example:** David replies to Sarah's email, thanking her for the update and formally approving the new deadline. He also offers assistance if she needs any resources to solve the technical issues. This feedback allows Sarah to confirm that her request was understood and accepted.

IMPROVING BUSINESS COMMUNICATION

Following are some of the ways business communication can be improved.



COMMITTING TO ETHICAL COMMUNICATION

Distinguishing Ethical Dilemmas from Ethical Lapses

Some ethical questions are easy to recognize and resolve, but others are not. Deciding what is ethical in complex business situations is not always easy. An **ethical dilemma** involves choosing among alternatives that aren't clear-cut. **If you must choose between two ethical alternatives, you are facing an ethical dilemma.** Perhaps two conflicting

alternatives are both ethical and valid, or perhaps the alternatives lie somewhere in the gray area between clearly right and clearly wrong. Every company has responsibilities to multiple groups of people inside and outside the firm, and those various groups often have competing interests.

For instance, employees generally want higher wages and more benefits, but investors who have risked their money in the company want management to keep costs low so that profits are strong enough to drive up the stock price. Both sides have a valid ethical position.

In contrast, an **ethical lapse** is a clearly unethical choice. With both internal and external communication efforts, the pressure to produce results or justify decisions can make unethical communication a tempting choice.

Telling a potential customer you can complete a project by a certain date when you know you can't is simply dishonest, even if you need the contract to save your career or your company. There is no ethical dilemma here.

Ethical Dilemma	Ethical Lapse
Maria, a sales rep, promotes an expensive new drug. While effective, it has side effects and cheaper alternatives exist. She's torn between boosting company sales and ensuring patient well-being by suggesting cheaper options. Dilemma: Should Maria promote the drug for sales or recommend cheaper, safer alternatives for patients?	John, a financial officer, is pressured to falsify his company's earnings to attract investors. He deliberately inflates revenue and hides debt in the financial reports. Lapse: John knowingly engages in unethical behavior by falsifying reports.

Making Ethical Choices

When making ethical choices, asking the following questions helps ensure that decisions align with legal, moral, and practical standards.

1. Is this message legal?

Before sending or communicating any message, it's essential to check if it complies with laws and regulations. Illegal content (e.g., false advertising, defamatory statements) can have serious legal consequences.

Example: A company promoting a product must ensure their claims are truthful and supported by evidence to avoid violating advertising laws.

2. Is this message balanced?

A balanced message is fair and considers all perspectives. It doesn't mislead, exaggerate, or favor one side unjustly. Ethical communication avoids bias and distortion of facts.

Example: If you're presenting a report to management, providing both the pros and cons of a situation ensures a balanced perspective.

3. Can you live with this message?

This refers to personal accountability. Can you be proud of this message? Will you be comfortable if others, like your colleagues or the public, see it? If not, it's a sign that the message might be ethically questionable.

Example: If a manager sends an email blaming an employee for a mistake to cover their own error, they might later feel guilty or face backlash for unfairly shifting blame.

4. Is this message feasible?

A message should be realistic and achievable. If you're making promises or setting expectations, ensure they are realistic to avoid future disappointment or mistrust.

Example: A company should not promise 24-hour delivery if they know logistical constraints make it impossible, as this would lead to broken promises and dissatisfied customers.

ADOPTING AN AUDIENCE-CENTERED APPROACH

An **audience-centered approach** involves understanding and respecting the members of your audience and making every effort to get your message across in a way that is meaningful to them. This approach is also known as adopting the **"you" attitude**, in contrast to messages that are about "me." **Learn as much as possible about the biases, education, age, status, style, and personal and professional concerns of your receivers.** If you're addressing people you don't know and you're unable to find out more about them, try to envision yourself in their position using common sense and imagination. This ability to relate to the needs of others is a key part of **emotional intelligence**, a combination of emotional and social skills widely considered to be a vital characteristic of successful managers and leaders. The more you know about the people you're communicating with, the easier it will be to concentrate on their needs — which, in turn, will make it easier for them to hear your message, understand it, and respond positively.

A vital element of audience-centered communication is **etiquette**, the expected norms of behavior in any particular situation. In today's hectic, competitive world, etiquette might seem a quaint and outdated notion. However, the way you conduct yourself and interact with others can have a profound influence on your company's success and your career. When executives hire and promote you, they expect your behavior to protect the company's reputation. The more you understand such expectations, the better chance you have of avoiding career-damaging mistakes.

DEVELOPING INTERCULTURAL SENSITIVITY

Following are some of the ways intercultural sensitivity can be developed.



1. Recognizing Cultural Differences

You don't need to become an expert in the details of every culture with which you do business, but you do need to attain a basic level of cultural proficiency to ensure successful communication. You can start by recognizing and accommodating the differences described in the following sections.

Cultural Context

In business communication, understanding the difference between high-context and low-context cultures is crucial for effective interactions, especially in a global environment. The two concepts, proposed by anthropologist Edward T. Hall, describe how much information is embedded in the context or message itself.

A. High-Context Cultures

In high-context cultures, communication relies heavily on the context surrounding the message — non-verbal cues, tone of voice, body language, and the relationships between individuals. The message is often implicit, and much of the meaning is drawn from the situation, rather than the actual words spoken. **The primary role of communication in high-context cultures is building relationships, not exchanging information.**

Examples of High-Context Cultures: Japan, China, Saudi Arabia, Bangladesh, and India.

Implication in Business Communication: In high-context cultures, communication tends to be more indirect, nuanced, and relationship-based. Building trust is essential before business deals can move forward. People expect the listener to read between the lines and understand unspoken rules.

- ⊕ A Japanese executive might hesitate to say "no" directly in a meeting, as it could be seen as impolite or confrontational. Instead, they might say, "We will consider this carefully," implying a negative response without explicitly saying so. An American business partner unfamiliar with Japanese culture might misinterpret this and think the proposal is still under consideration, when it's actually being declined.
- ⊕ In India, during negotiations, the focus is often on establishing personal relationships. Detailed contracts may not be discussed until much later, after rapport has been built.

B. Low-Context Cultures

In low-context cultures, communication is more explicit and direct. Most of the information is conveyed through words, and there's little reliance on non-verbal cues or shared understanding. What is said is what is meant, with less room for interpretation. **The primary task of communication in low-context cultures is exchanging information.**

Examples of Low-Context Cultures: United States, Germany, Australia, and the Netherlands.

Implication in Business Communication: In low-context cultures, business communication tends to be more straightforward and efficient, focusing on facts, figures, and clarity. People expect clear and direct communication without the need for reading between the lines.

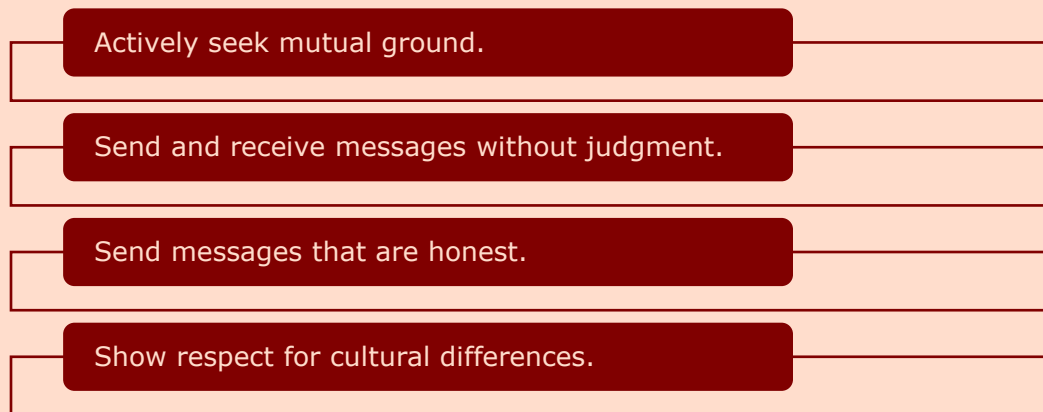
- ⊕ In the U.S., if a manager is unhappy with an employee's performance, they are more likely to directly address the issue, saying something like, "Your performance needs improvement in these specific areas." The feedback is clear, and action steps are outlined without ambiguity.
- ⊕ In Germany, business communication is often concise, with direct and precise instructions. There's little room for vague statements, and meetings are task-oriented, focusing on problem-solving and decision-making.

Legal and Ethical Differences

Cultural context influences legal and ethical behavior, which in turn can affect communication. For example, the meaning of business contracts can vary from culture to culture. While a manager from a U.S. company would tend to view a signed contract as the end of the

negotiating process, with all the details hammered out, his or her counterpart in many Asian cultures might view the signed contract as an agreement to do business — and only then begin to negotiate the details of the deal.

As you conduct business with colleagues and customers around the world, you'll find that legal systems and ethical standards differ from culture to culture. Making ethical choices across cultures can seem complicated, but you can keep your messages ethical by applying the following four principles.



Social Customs

Social behavior is guided by numerous rules, some of them formal and specifically articulated (table manners are a good example) and others more informal and learned over time (such as the comfortable standing distance between two speakers in an office). The combination of formal and informal rules influences the overall behavior of everyone in a society in areas such as **manners, attitudes toward time, individual versus community values, attitudes toward status and wealth, respect for authority, degrees of openness and inclusiveness, and conflict resolution.**

These social customs affect how people behave in the workplace, and differences can create communication problems. For instance, the French cosmetics company L'Oreal trains its global workforce in a standardized approach to conflict management that encourages employees to express disagreement and share competing ideas. In the beginning, this style felt unnatural for its Chinese employees, whose culture discouraged open debate, but they grew to appreciate the advantages of the approach.

Understanding the nuances of social customs takes time and effort, but most businesspeople are happy to explain the habits and expectations of their culture. Plus, they will view your curiosity as a sign of respect.

Nonverbal Communication

Nonverbal communication (communicating without the use of words) is a vital part of the communication process. Factors ranging from facial expressions to style of dress can influence the way receivers decode messages, and the interpretation of nonverbal signals can vary widely from culture to culture. Gestures or clothing choices that you don't think twice about, for example, might seem inappropriate or even offensive to someone from another culture.

Nonverbal communication can indeed vary widely across cultures. Here are two specific examples.

1. Facial Expressions (Japan vs. U.S.)

In the United States, smiling is often used as a universal gesture of friendliness or approachability. It's common to smile at strangers, even in brief interactions like passing someone in a hallway or meeting them for the first time.

However, in Japan, smiling can have more nuanced meanings. While smiles are also used to express happiness or friendliness, they can sometimes mask discomfort, embarrassment, or even disapproval. For example, a Japanese businessperson might smile politely during a discussion, even if they disagree with what is being said. In contrast, an American might interpret this smile as agreement or approval, leading to a misunderstanding.

2. Hand Gestures (U.S. vs. Middle East)

In the United States, giving a "thumbs-up" gesture is a common sign of approval or positivity. It's often used in casual conversations to indicate "everything is good" or "well done."

However, in some parts of the Middle East, the thumbs-up gesture is considered offensive, similar to showing the middle finger in Western cultures. What seems like a simple, positive gesture in one culture can be highly disrespectful in another, leading to unintended offense in cross-cultural communication.

2. Overcoming Ethnocentrism

Ethnocentrism is the belief that one's own culture or ethnic group is superior to others, leading to misunderstanding and miscommunication in cross-cultural interactions. People with ethnocentric views often evaluate other cultures based on the standards of their own, rather than appreciating cultural differences.

Example: A manager from the U.S. might assume that American work habits, such as a fast-paced environment and direct communication, are the most efficient. When dealing with colleagues from Japan, where business meetings might involve more time for relationship-building and less direct confrontation, the manager may view this approach as inefficient or overly cautious, failing to appreciate the cultural context.

Following are some of the ways one can overcome ethnocentrism.

⊕ Accept Distinctions

Recognize and appreciate that different cultures have unique ways of doing things. Instead of assuming there's a "right" or "wrong" way, embrace these distinctions as different, but equally valid.

Example: In some cultures, such as in Brazil, personal space is smaller, and people stand closer during conversations. Accepting this difference helps avoid discomfort or misunderstanding.

⊕ Avoid Assumptions

Don't assume that people from other cultures share the same beliefs, values, or practices as you. Take the time to understand the cultural norms before making assumptions about behavior.

Example: A Western businessperson might assume that a colleague's lack of eye contact in a meeting shows disinterest. However, in cultures like Japan or South Korea, avoiding eye contact is often a sign of respect, especially towards authority.

⊕ **Avoid Judgments**

Resist the urge to judge another culture's practices or beliefs based on your own cultural standards. Instead of viewing differences as "better" or "worse," try to understand the reasoning behind them.

Example: In countries like India, hierarchy plays a major role in workplace communication, where subordinates may not question superiors openly. Instead of judging this practice as ineffective, it's important to understand the cultural importance of respect for authority.

3. Polishing Written Intercultural Skills

Ideally, businesses can communicate with employees, customers, and other stakeholders in their native languages, and many companies invest a lot of time and money in translating print and online communication to achieve this. However, translation isn't always cost effective or possible. To write effectively for people who may not be comfortable using your language, remember the following tips.

- ⊕ **Use plain language.** Use short, precise words that say exactly what you mean.
- ⊕ **Avoid words with multiple meanings.** As much as possible, choose words that have only one obvious meaning in the context in which you're using them. For example, "right" has more than 30 distinct meanings and can function as a noun, an adjective, a verb, and an adverb. Whenever it is appropriate, use a synonym that conveys the specific meaning you intend, such as **correct, appropriate, desirable, moral, authentic, or privilege.**
- ⊕ **Be clear.** Rely on specific terms and concrete examples to explain your points.
- ⊕ **Cite numbers carefully.** Use numerals (such as "27") instead of spelling them out ("twenty-seven").
- ⊕ **Avoid slang and be careful with technical jargon and abbreviations.** Slang and other nonstandard usages can be difficult or impossible for your audience to translate.
- ⊕ **Be brief.** Construct sentences that are short and simple.
- ⊕ **Use short paragraphs.** Each paragraph should stick to one topic.
- ⊕ **Use transitions generously.** Help readers follow your train of thought.

4. Developing Oral Communication Skills

When speaking to people whose native language is not your own, you will find these tips helpful.

- ⊕ **Speak clearly, simply, and relatively slowly.** Pronounce words clearly, stop at distinct punctuation points, and make one point at a time.
- ⊕ **Look for feedback, but interpret it carefully.** Nods and smiles don't necessarily indicate understanding.
- ⊕ **Rephrase if necessary.** If someone doesn't seem to understand you, rephrase using simpler words.
- ⊕ **Clarify your meaning with repetition and examples.** Use concrete and specific examples to illustrate difficult or vague ideas.
- ⊕ **Don't talk down to the other person.** Don't blame the listener for not understanding. Say, "Am I going too fast?" rather than "Is this too difficult for you?"
- ⊕ **Learn important phrases in your audience's language.** Learning common greetings and a few simple phrases simplifies initial contact and shows respect.
- ⊕ **Listen carefully and respectfully.** If you do not understand a comment, ask the person to repeat it.
- ⊕ **Adapt your conversation style to the other person's.** For instance, if the other person seems to be direct and straightforward, follow suit.
- ⊕ **Check frequently for comprehension.** After you make each point, pause to gauge the other person's comprehension before moving on.

- ⊕ **Clarify what will happen next.** At the end of a conversation, be sure that you and the other person agree on what has been said and decided.

IMPROVING WORKPLACE SENSITIVITY

Improving workplace sensitivity involves embracing cultural differences and fostering respectful communication. The following strategies can surely help build a more inclusive, understanding, and culturally aware workplace.

- ⊕ **Assume differences.** Expect differences in values, behaviors, and communication styles rather than assuming everyone shares your perspective.
- ⊕ **Take responsibility.** Own your actions and communication, ensuring you contribute positively to the workplace environment.
- ⊕ **Withhold judgment.** Avoid making snap judgments about behaviors or practices that differ from your own.
- ⊕ **Be respectful.** Show respect for everyone's cultural norms and individual preferences, even when they're unfamiliar to you.
- ⊕ **Show empathy.** Understand and share the feelings of others, especially in unfamiliar situations.
- ⊕ **Tolerate ambiguity.** Be comfortable with unclear or unfamiliar situations, as cross-cultural exchanges often involve uncertainty.
- ⊕ **Look past the superficial.** Focus on deeper cultural values and beliefs rather than just appearances or surface behaviors.
- ⊕ **Be patient.** Allow time for understanding to develop, especially when communicating across cultures.
- ⊕ **Be persistent.** Keep trying to improve cross-cultural communication, even when challenges arise.
- ⊕ **Admit cultural biases.** Recognize your own biases and work to overcome them.
- ⊕ **Stay flexible.** Be adaptable to different cultural contexts and adjust your communication style accordingly.
- ⊕ **Find common ground.** Look for shared interests and values that can bridge cultural differences.
- ⊕ **Send clear messages.** Communicate clearly and avoid vague or ambiguous language.
- ⊕ **Deal with individuals.** Treat each person as an individual, rather than assuming they fully represent their culture.
- ⊕ **Learn when to be direct.** Understand when it's appropriate to be direct or indirect based on cultural norms.
- ⊕ **Test your understanding.** Check in with others to ensure you're interpreting their communication accurately.

REVIEW AND DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

A. Theoretical/Conceptual Questions

1. What is communication?
2. The modern workplace is constantly evolving due to the following several key factors. Explain the factors with examples.
3. When does effective communication occur?
4. What are the benefits of effective communication?
5. Explain the basic communication model. Provide a specific example.
6. Write about some of the ways business communication can be improved.
7. What are the differences between an ethical dilemma and an ethical lapse? Explain with examples.
8. What questions help ensure that decisions align with legal, moral, and practical standards?
9. What is an audience-centered approach?
10. What are some of the ways intercultural sensitivity can be developed?
11. What is cultural context?
12. Write about high-context and low-context cultures with examples.
13. What are some implications of high-context and low-context cultures in business communication?
14. How do legal and ethical differences affect business communication?
15. How do social customs affect business communication?
16. How does nonverbal communication affect business communication?
17. What is ethnocentrism? How can one overcome ethnocentrism?
18. What are some tips one can follow to improve their written intercultural skills?
19. What are some tips one can follow to develop oral communication skills?
20. How can workplace sensitivity be improved?

B. Situational/Contextual Questions

1. Why can it be argued that communication is the most important business skill?
2. How does your understanding of the communication process help you conduct business more effectively?
3. What changes would you make to your email messages if you know your recipients typically read them while walking or riding on mass transit?
4. You're the CEO of a company whose sales are declining, and there is a 50–50 chance you will need to lay off some of your employees sometime in the next two to three months. You have to decide whether to tell them now so they can look for new jobs as soon as possible, even though you're not yet sure layoffs will be necessary, or wait until you are sure layoffs will occur. Explain why this is an ethical dilemma. Be sure to consider the effect a sudden exodus of valuable employees could have on the company's prospects.
5. Why is it important to understand your own culture when attempting to communicate with people from other cultures?

C. Improve Your Grammar, Mechanics, and Usage

Use the following self-assessment exercises to improve your knowledge of and power over English grammar, mechanics, and usage.

Level 1: Self-Assessment—Nouns

For the following items, indicate which words are common nouns and which are proper nouns.

1. Give the balance sheet to Melissa.
2. After three years of declining sales, the board fired the CEO and hired a replacement from Google.
3. Tarnower Corporation donates a portion of its profits to charity every year.
4. Which aluminum bolts are packaged?
5. Please send the Joneses a dozen of each of the following: stopwatches, canteens, headbands, and wristbands.

For the following items, underline the subjects and circle the objects.

6. The technician has already repaired the machine for the client.
7. An attorney will talk to the group about incorporation.
8. After her vacation, the buyer prepared a third-quarter budget.
9. More than 90 percent of the research staff has contributed to the new wiki.
10. Accuracy overrides speed in importance.

For the following items, indicate any inappropriate noun plurals and possessives and provide the correct form.

11. Make sure that all copys include the new addresses.
12. Ask Jennings to collect all employee's donations for the Red Cross drive.
13. Charlie now has two son-in-laws to help him with his two online business's.
14. Avoid using too many parenthesis when writing your reports.
15. Follow President Nesses rules about what constitutes a weeks work.

Level 2: Workplace Applications

The following items may contain errors in grammar, capitalization, punctuation, abbreviation, number style, word division, and vocabulary. Rewrite each sentence, correcting all errors. If a sentence has no errors, write "Correct" for that number.

16. If a broken down unproductive guy like Carl can get a raise; why can't a take charge guy like me get one?
17. Visit our website and sign up for "On Your Toes", our free newsletter that keeps you informed of promotions, discounts and about Internet-only specials.
18. As of March, 2018, the Board of Directors have 9 members including: three women, one African-American, and one American of Hispanic descent.
19. As one of the nearly 3,000,000 New York Life policyholders eligible to vote, we urge you to approve the new investment advisory agreement.
20. Gerrald Higgins, vice president for marketing, told us reporters that Capital One provides financial services to one-fourth of homes in the United States.
21. Our Customer Relations associates work with people everyday to answer questions, provide assistance, and helping solve problems.
22. If anyone breaches the lease, its likely that the landlord will file legal action against them to collect on the remain der of they're lease.
23. A IRA is one of the most common plans for the self-employed because of it's ease of setting up and administering.
24. My advise to you is, to put you're mission statement on your web cite.
25. According to Karen Smiths' report small-business owners do'nt recognize the full effect that layoffs and terminations are liable to have on the motivation of surviving employees'.
26. To exacerbate the processing of your US tax return, use the mailing label and bar coded envelope that comes with your tax package.
27. The NASE have implemented a exciting array of programs that make it more easy for legislative opinions and concerns to be voiced by you.
28. Keep in mind the old saying "When we laugh the world laugh with us, when you cry you cry alone."
29. Albert Edmunds and me are Owners of the real estate firm of Edmunds & Cale, which have recently opened a new office in San Diego co.
30. The memo inferred that the economic downturn will have a greater affect on the company's bottom line then we previously assumed, this was the worse news we could of gotten.